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PACIFIC

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PACIFIC



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THE PACIFIC

I WAS BORN ON AN ISLAND in the Pacific—the South Island of New Zealand—and within sight of the ocean. To me it was simply the sea: a part of the accepted order of things, its horizon an ever-present, but scarcely noticed, reminder that my home was an island in a vast and moody ocean.

The years of my youth just touched the fringe of the age of the great Pacific adventurers. My family spent summers at Purakanui on the Otago coast in an old house built by Dickie Driver, a deserter from a whaler, whose cutlass and muzzle-loading musket were still up there in the loft. He had been one of the first white men to live on the South Island of New Zealand, and I heard many tales of the early days from an old man who was Dickie Driver's grandson.

My maternal grandparents came to New Zealand as part of the wave of colonists who came from Scotland and England in the 1840s and 50s. My father sailed from Scotland as a young man of eighteen, around Cape Horn in a sailing ship that took six months to reach New Zealand.

Thus I claim my heritage in these islands in the Pacific. I do not of course forget that, in a sense, though born here I am an intruder. The ancestors of my Maori friends came here as early as the fourteenth century, five hundred years before mine, but the day is coming when we shall be one and the same people.

In this book I am concerned with the Pacific and what might be called its original caste, so I have concentrated on the original or the earlier inhabitants. Thus for instance in Australia I painted the Aborigines rather than the dinkum Aussies.

The years when the culture of London and Europe lured me away from my Pacific home were not unhappy but they were, in my heart, years of exile. Always, in spite of my English and Scottish blood, there was the sense of being in an alien land. In the years between I travelled the face of the earth and I am happily at ease in the Via Veneto, Fifth Avenue, or the Champs Elysees, but my own country in the Pacific has become my home again now, and I am at peace.

This sense of peace is not just that of a tired man who has turned his footsteps home: it comes from the fact that the Pacific is the last great unspoiled area on this earth.

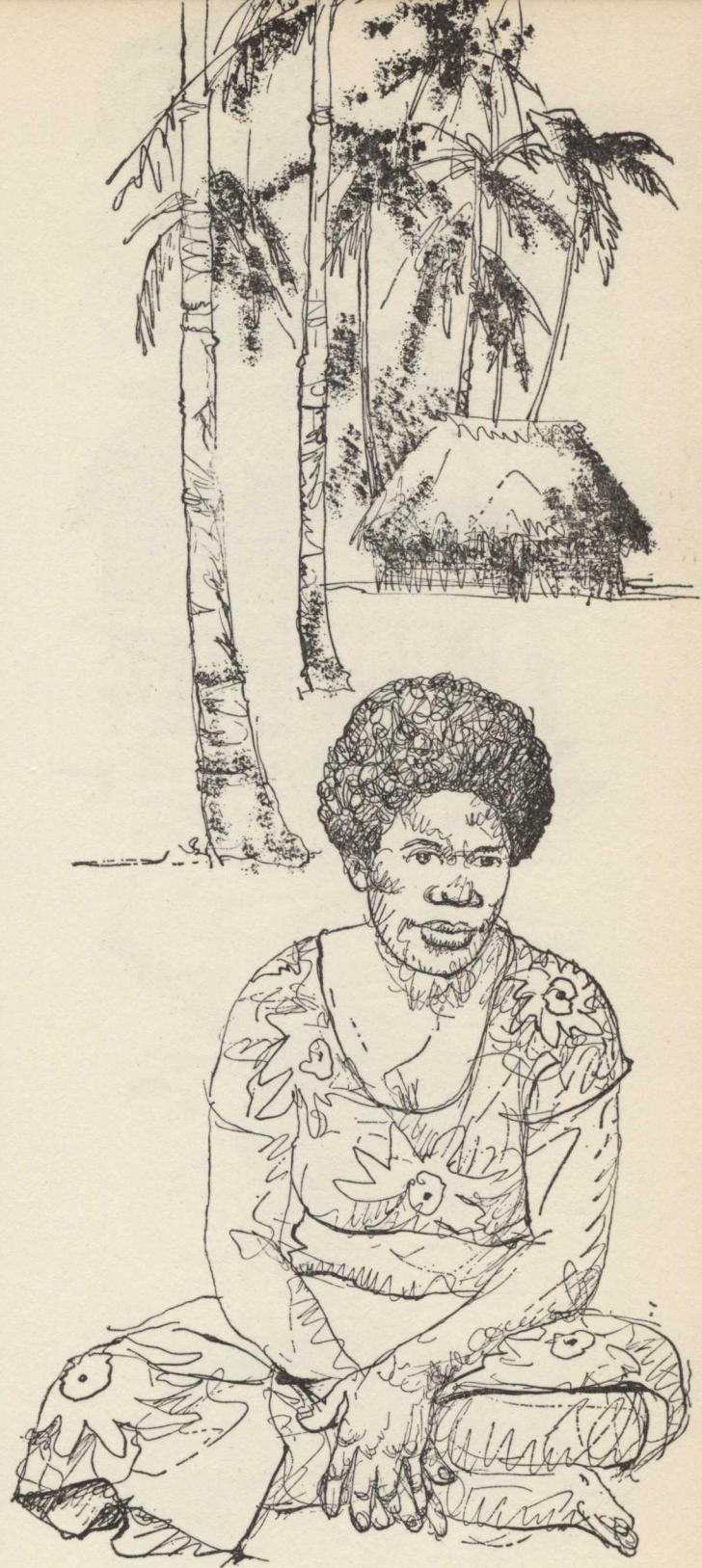
Europe is worn and weary, overrun by hordes of people in search of a culture and a grandeur that Europeans themselves are making tawdry and touristy. America is a nightmare of so-called progress; only the Pacific remains as a place where man can live at peace with his surroundings. Visually, both North and South Pacific retain much of the beauty that Nature heaped upon them so lavishly.

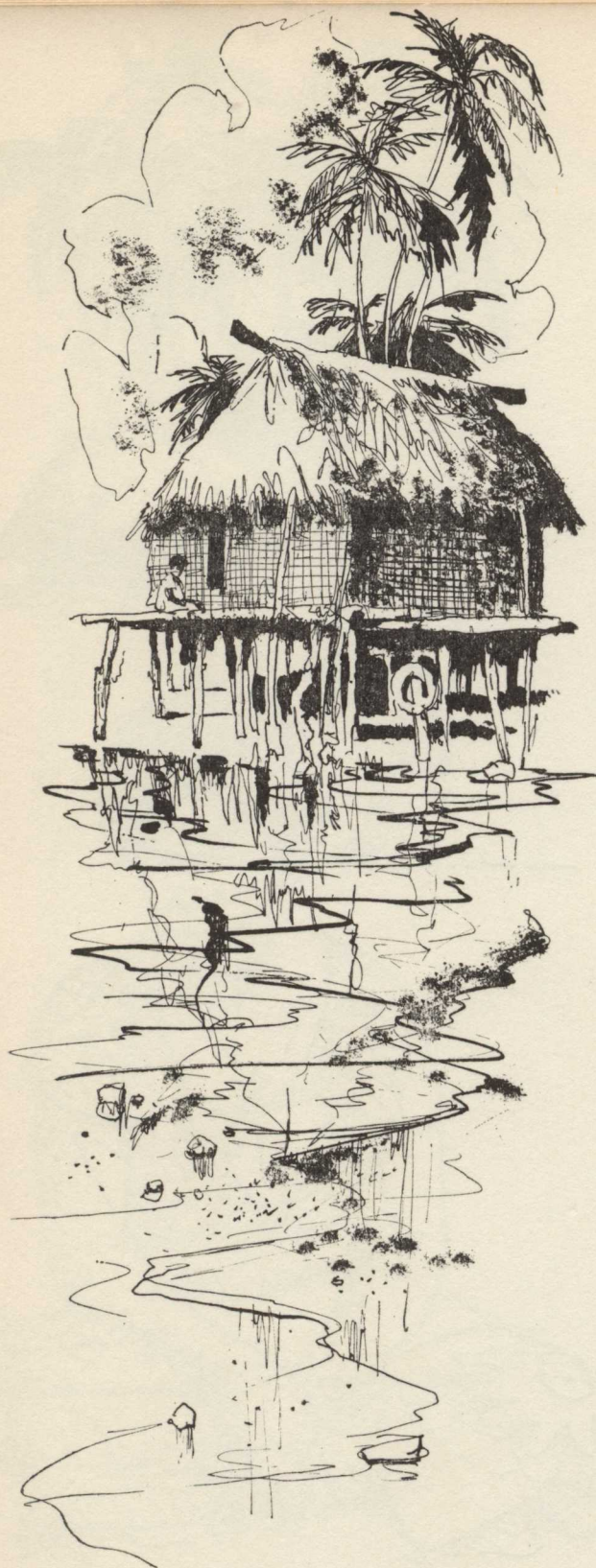
The Pacific has been protected by time. Even the North Pacific remained aloof from our Western world until well within living memory and the South Pacific, by European standards of time, was but recently populated. The islands of the Pacific were probably settled some four or five hundred years after the birth of Christ. The great Pacific adventurers, impelled by some unknown force, and coming from Asia by way of Micronesia spread out across the Pacific from island to island.

These were heroic people. A haunting song still sung in Tahiti is the song of departure. When the population became too big the ruler would order a group of his people to set out in canoes to find other lands to live on—or to die at sea.

These migrations were so recent that in New Zealand the Maoris can still name not only the first canoes to arrive but the beaches they arrived on and the names of many of the occupants. This was handed down by word of mouth from father to son as the Maori had no written language.

The next period, that of the exploration of the Pacific by the white man is dom-





FIJI

inated by one great figure—that of Captain James Cook. Throughout my own travels in the Pacific I was reminded so often of Cook that in the end he became as real a person as though I had known him: aloof but kindly, modest but determined, as one sees him in the portrait by Sir Nathaniel Dance painted after his return from the second voyage.

In the Pacific it is still possible to find primitive man. In New Guinea there are tribes up the Sepik River who until just recently did not know that the white man existed, and in that country, where the incongruous is a commonplace, you can still see primitive man with his bow and arrows walking by your modern hotel.

In the North Pacific Japan and Hong Kong, although they have embraced Western industrialisation to a suicidal point of no return, retain so much of their own highly individual Japanese and Chinese culture and customs that each is still an enthralling and exciting feast for Western eyes.

All this heady blend of colour, custom, and climate, brought suddenly within range by air travel, has made the Pacific the playground of the world.

In this book I have recorded some fragments of it—gratefully, because in a few short years this Pacific of mine will be totally altered and much of its colour will have disappeared under the creeping mass of Sameness that we call Progress.

FIJI

Fiji to us is still a little like home. In fact, in Suva itself the New Zealand influence has produced a somewhat suburban air, a sort of prevailing mediocrity; but outside Suva there is much of charm and interest.

The first thing the modern traveller must do is recuperate from the effort of leaving home—all those visas—so we hired a car and drove straight to Koro Levu where for the next few days we lay on the beach breathing in our freedom from domesticity, from electricity bills and telephone bells.

The coast of Fiji around Koro Levu is very lovely and in the early mornings before the heat of the day I drove out through groves of palms to headlands that looked out over beaches and coral reefs. There were villages of thatched huts, neat and pretty under the palms, and I stopped to talk to the school children. I wasn't sure which were boys and which were girls, for in Fiji girls have their hair cut short and boys wear a sort of skirt, and only a sort of big-eyed softness of look identifies the girls.

I gave a lift to two young women—their hair was a little longer—and they gently mocked my white-man-boss air of superiority (I had been unconscious of it until that moment) by over emphasising the “sir” and being just too attentive to every trite remark I made. Nonetheless they invited me into their village when I stopped to let them off. It was such a cool and peaceful spot under a canopy of the green foliage of huge trees. The people were sitting about even at that hour, great fat women in dresses of startling island prints. I would call them plain women; but there was something majestic about them as they sat with that faraway look of people to whom time means nothing. They let me sketch them with good humour and much joking in their own tongue. Somehow the jokes sounded ribald. They probably were—and I felt that I was at last on a South Sea Island.

We paused for a few days only in Suva, it being just a bit too much like home. Old friends Susan and Ray Parkinson gave a party for us, I lectured to the art club, and old friend Charlie Marsack, a retired judge with whom I had soldiered in the Western Desert, had us to a cocktail party. This was pleasant indeed but I couldn't paint it.

Kava Ceremony: Then two things saved the day. The Council of Chiefs was in session, a rare event, and I was bidden to see the kava ceremony by which the chiefs from all the islands of Fiji honour the Governor. This was an all-male gathering in the grounds

of Government House, a ceremony that seemed somehow dated, as though one were seeing a film made in Victorian times.

The chiefs, fine-looking men, sat cross-legged on the matting wearing skirts, as is their custom. Beside me sat another old friend with whom I had soldiered in the Western Desert, Kim Morrison, commanding the local forces and resplendent in white dress uniform. The Governor appeared, also resplendent in white and wearing a cocked hat. The chiefs greeted him with a deep throaty roar that seemed to say "Isn't he magnificent!"

The carcase of an enormous pig was carried in on a pole, as an offering to the Governor, and carried out again.

Then came the ceremony itself. A group of Fijian men, fibre-skirted, wearing garlands of leaves around arms and ankles, and with their eyes fearsomely blackened, carried in a huge wooden bowl. The roots of a pepperplant were squeezed into it to make a milky fluid and with great solemnity a coconut bowl of it was carried to the Governor. He bravely quaffed it in one, which was his bounden duty, and all the chiefs clapped their hands crying "*Matha-a-a!* It is dry, it is finished."

Later I noticed the Governor signal to an aide for a glass of water which he also quaffed in one. I thought he was letting the side down a bit there.

Bau: The other event that enlivened our stay in Suva was an invitation to visit the old cannibal island of Bau. We were lucky indeed. You do not ask to go to Bau, you hope to be asked. To ask would be like going to Buckingham Palace and asking the Queen to let you roam around a bit.

Bau is a tiny island—you can wade across to it at low tide—but in the hierarchy of Fiji it stood at the top. By sheer force of conquest it had proved itself strongest during the tribal wars and at the time of the signing of Deed of Cession it was the seat of Cakobau (pronounced Kakombau) who was recognised as being the paramount chief and King of Fiji.

It was difficult for us arriving on this island of waving palms to believe that not so long ago—in fact right up until the 1880s—cannibal feasts had taken place here when as many as two hundred captives at a time were cooked and eaten.

In Fiji the object of cannibalism was to subject the defeated enemy to the ultimate humiliation. Another reason was simply that there was no beef. There was pig only, and human flesh was known as "long pig".

When King Cakobau laid down his war club he presented it to Queen Victoria with a letter saying "The King gives Her Majesty his old and favourite war-club, the former, and, until lately, the only known law of Fiji."

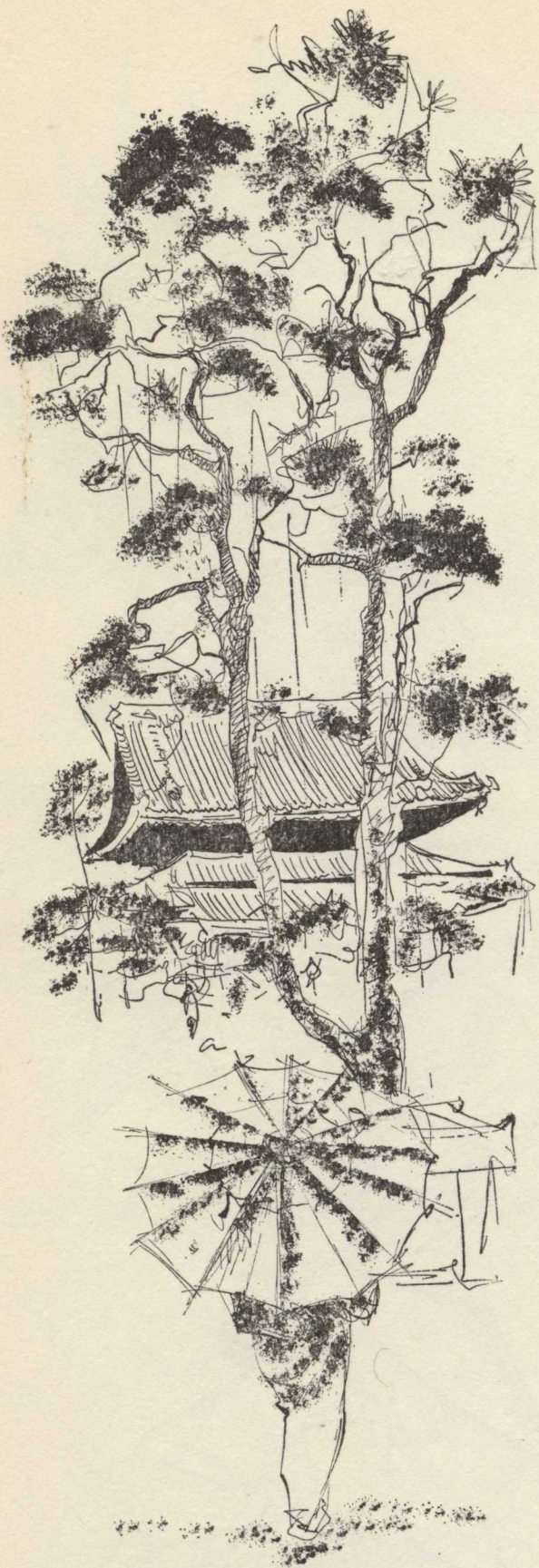
He then became a Christian and built the church that now stands on Bau. In that church is one of the strangest baptismal fonts in all Christendom. It is the slaughterstone against which the heads of many hundreds of war victims were dashed before the bodies were sent to the cannibal ovens. The stone was consecrated and is now the baptismal font.

There is a lovely green overhung with huge trees in the centre of Bau and beside it a fine meeting-house built on a mound of stones and with a high thatched roof where chiefly assemblies were held. This had been the heathen temple. Beside it was an old ship's anchor and a whaleboat's rudder encased in copper long turned green. I asked some of the men about them, but nobody seemed to know; I asked about the bad old days, but it was of no use: they wanted to tell me about the Fijian cricket team that visited New Zealand.

The children played on the green beside the old heathen temple and all was peace. King Cakobau's warriors are gone now and the past is perhaps best forgotten.

The Yasawas: We sailed out of Lautoka in Oscar Wright's boat *Sayandra* for the Yasawa Islands, a group that lies to the north-west of Veti Levu. Life on Oscar's boat





JAPAN

"What will happen to it when you're gone?" I asked him.
 "It'll go back to the Mexicans," he shrugged.
 He is a happy man.

16

Acapulco : Acapulco is in Mexico but it is not Mexico. It is something that happened to Mexico. Film stars build their houses there. Huge hotels tower above its beach and the lots across the way are a litter of shacks, for only twenty years ago this was a fisherman's village. The fishermen still sleep in the heat of the day under their boats and nets, but on a small portion of beach roped off between the hotels.

You can go from nightclub to nightclub, bar to bar, from the daylight of today to the daylight of tomorrow, if for some reason you want to. In fact one de-luxe hotel has a bar in the middle of its swimming pool.

We stayed in a new type of hotel, high on the hillside above the bay in a bungalow all our own, its terrace cantilevered out among the tropical trees and with its own swimming pool. When we came in the first evening and switched on the lights the swimming pool became a soft turquoise, lit from below.

We giggled a bit but couldn't resist it. Nor could we resist the lolly-pink-striped jeep with the fringed canopy at our disposal to drive down to the restaurant or down to the beachclub where the sea comes into a great natural rock pool. We lay on mattresses under striped umbrellas and every few minutes a jeep with a canopied bar on it slowly circled the pool dispensing drinks.

Then all of a sudden one day it was enough. I put down my fruit-bedecked rum-and-pineapple and said "Let's get the hell out of here."

HAWAII

When Captain Cook made his first landing in Hawaii it was on the island of Kauai—had the wind been right, by the way, he would have sailed into what is now Pearl Harbour in Oahu. The people he found there had never seen Europeans before and didn't even know they existed.

The contrast of the arrival of Patty and me in the same place is a measure of what has happened to Hawaii, and to Kauai in particular, in the years since Cook landed in 1778.

Flying from Kauai, we hired a drive-yourself car at the airport in less time than it takes to get a taxi back home and drove along roads between fields of pineapple and of sugar cane, and huge market gardens.

We stayed in a very pleasant hotel on Poipu Beach that was once the home of the Knudsen family who started the first cattle ranch and planted the first commercial sugar cane on Kauai; it was one of those hotels common in the Hawaiian Islands that make it almost unnecessary ever to venture beyond the garden. Life becomes almost too easy with a golden beach, a swimming pool among the rocks above the breakers, and a climate seldom too hot and never too cold. Add to this Hawaiian dancers and singers, palatial rooms in bungalows in glorious tropical gardens, a library, and a bar.

Yet on venturing forth we found that beyond the sugar cane and the pineapples is an island of primordial canyons and mist-shrouded mountains. Mount Waialeale has the heaviest rainfall in the world yet the beaches a few miles away lie in sunshine all the year round. I realised that I too was becoming inclined to lie in the sunshine all the year round. It was time to move—to another beach on another island.

Maui : Our good friend Irma Attridge, the Californian painter, told us to go to Hana Maui, as it was at the remote far end of Maui and peaceful. In fact it is so remote that the succeeding waves of Chinese, Portuguese, Japanese, Puerto Rican, Korean,



PLATE 6

FIJI: *Fijian Girl*. The Fijian girl was shy and smiling by the roadside on the island of Ovalau with her seashells for sale, her hair cut short like a boy's, which is the Fijian style for girls.

I painted the landscape in the interior of Ovalau, a few miles from Levuka. These banana leaves have become to me the very symbol of the lushness that fills the Islands.



Fijian Landscape





PLATE 40

AUSTRALIA: *Funeral Dance*. We went by boat out from Darwin to a rocky point on the coast where the Aborigines were burying an elder of the tribe—at least, this was the final ceremony of burning his possessions and dancing his ghost into the ground. The chanting, the strange music of the didgeridoo and the magnificent dancing of the men seemed to date back into another age of Man. In spite of the odd bits of white man's clothing the scene made me feel as though I were looking through a peephole in the curtain of Time.





Aboriginal Children

PLATE 45

AUSTRALIA: *The Glasshouse Mountains.* I could not resist Aboriginal children yet I wanted to weep for them, for theirs is the innate sadness of a doomed race. For a little while yet they may sit in their place in the sand and the sun.

Those strange crags opposite were named by Captain Cook as he sailed along the coast past what is now Brisbane. Presumably they glinted in the sun and so he gave them the name Glasshouse; but Cook was not one to explain the names he gave, for Cook was never a bore.





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